

John Pocock and the Jealousy of Trade

Richard Whatmore  and Lasse S. Andersen 

School of History, University of St Andrews, St Andrews, Scotland, UK

ABSTRACT

At the end of *The Machiavellian Moment*, J. G. A. Pocock was unclear about what happened to the classical republican/civic humanist tradition. Significantly, he did not make the anticipated point, following Hannah Arendt, who he drew upon at the end of the book, concerning the decline of civic virtue and the need for its reassertion. In subsequent work Pocock published little on the nineteenth century, but he continued to be obsessed by the fate of civic humanism, especially in his self-reflective final writings, published or written between 2014 and his death in 2023. Especially in his unpublished *Academic Reminiscences*, he tackled the question of how *The Machiavellian Moment* ought to have ended. Commenting upon his own work from *The Ancient Constitution* to the sixth and last volume of his *Barbarism and Religion* series, *Barbarism: Triumph in the West* (2015), Pocock emphasised the relationship between his own work and the jealousy of trade, the commitment of national governments to the pursuit of markets and the defeat of rivals economically. Jealousy of trade, as a historical force which had altered world politics, was associated most especially with the scholarship of István Hont, whose perspectives on political thought Pocock found to be dovetailing increasingly with his own.

KEYWORDS

J. G. A. Pocock; jealousy of trade; István Hont; Cambridge School; Machiavellian Moment; republicanism

History had gone beyond the Machiavellian moment into the crisis of the seaborne empires

[John Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, transcribed by Anna May Katz]

I

John Pocock recalled towards the end of his life that in adding a chapter on James Harrington to his first book, *The Ancient Constitution and the Feudal Law* (1957), and thereby moving beyond his Cambridge PhD thesis, he was taking a ‘radically new step ... without really knowing what I was doing.’¹ *The Machiavellian Moment* (1975) continued what he had termed ‘the Machiavellian meditation upon feudalism’ begun in *The Ancient Constitution* and continued in subsequent essays.²

Pocock’s central argument ran as follows: Long after the decay of Roman *virtù*, the former western provinces of Rome’s empire had seen the development of ‘Gothic’ land tenures, which were associated with the exercise of military power by landed nobilities. Tensions later arose, Pocock argued, when monarchs legitimised their sovereignty as the exercise of a Norman-style feudal law and in reaction their opponents resorted to an ancient Anglo-Saxon constitution or Frankish

CONTACT Richard Whatmore  rw56@st-andrews.ac.uk  School of History, St Katharine’s Lodge, The Scores, St Andrews, KY16 2BA, Scotland, UK

© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group
This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives License (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/>), which permits non-commercial re-use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited, and is not altered, transformed, or built upon in any way. The terms on which this article has been published allow the posting of the Accepted Manuscript in a repository by the author(s) or with their consent.

thèse nobiliaire.³ Looking back at the outbreak of civil war between Charles I and the parliamentarians in England, Harrington concluded that ‘modern prudence’ had failed to establish an equilibrium between the two sources of authority. The cause of the turmoil, he believed, could be traced to the collapse of the feudal nobility. In such circumstances, Harrington said, it was necessary to return to ‘ancient prudence’, a way of rooting free politics in the exercise of classical citizenship. *The Machiavellian Moment* took Harrington’s argument into eighteenth-century England, projecting it further still into the history of the United States of America.

In its final section *The Machiavellian Moment* packed an enormous punch; for here Pocock sought to explain the failure of Marxism to gain a foothold in North America. The book’s ironic conclusion was that North America’s peculiarity resided in the fact that this was the most ancient of modern societies:

The Americans ... inherited rhetorical and conceptual structures which ensured that venality in public officials, the growth of a military-industrial complex in government, other-directedness and one-dimensionality in individuals, could all be identified in terms continuous with those used in the classical analysis of corruption, the successive civic-humanist denunciations of Caesar and Lorenzo de’ Medici, Marlborough, Walpole, and Hamilton ... the unique conditions of the continental republic and its growth were perpetuating the Augustan tension between virtue and commerce, the Puritan tension between election and apostasy, the Machiavellian tension between virtue and expansion, and in general the humanist tension between the active civic life and the secular time-continuum in which it must be lived. Hence the persistence in America of messianic and jeremiad attitudes toward history; hence also, in part, the curious extent to which the most post-modern and post-industrial of societies continues to venerate pre-modern and anti-industrial values, symbols, and constitutional forms, and to suffer from its awareness of the tensions between practice and morality.⁴

On the other hand, the value systems of most other comparable commercial and industrial societies had changed since the eighteenth century. Pocock noted briefly that the French were distinctive from the time of the Revolution because of the ‘cult of Spartan and Roman antiquity’; wherever German Idealism flourished there was a ‘restating of the quarrel between value and history in terms of a vision of reason as the working out of history’s contradictions within the self’, while the British ‘were developing an ideology of administrative reform which claimed ... to reduce history to a science.’⁵ America fascinated nineteenth-century commentators because of its apparent uniqueness.⁶ Pocock cited Hegel’s view that America ‘lacked anything which he could recognise as a “state”’. But Pocock’s reading of this point was that Hegel had articulated the subsequent view made famous by Frederick Jackson Turner, that the expanding western frontier had acted as a safety valve, a factor which explained the absence of class conflict in the United States.⁷ It would then only be a matter of time, once the frontier had been pushed to its westernmost limit, for the United States to face the same problems as its European counterparts. Hegel’s prognosis was that ‘when land was filled [and] urbanisation, a standing army, and class conflicts would begin [then], a true “state” would be necessitated’, which meant in turn that ‘the dialectic of history ... would begin to operate’.⁸ Pocock’s argument accepted Hegel’s point but emphasised that American history permanently altered the context. For example, commitment across the United States to the civic humanist critique of commerce left little room for neo-Hegelian or Marxist conflicts pushed aside by the unique American dialectic of space versus time. Even the self-professed Hegelians of the United States, in fact, were not Hegelian in any European sense of the term.⁹

As John Robertson notes in ‘John Pocock’s histories of historiography’, Pocock made effective use of the distinctions Hannah Arendt employed in *The Human Condition* (1958) between *homo politicus*, *homo mercator*, and *homo faber*.¹⁰ Robertson makes the point too that Pocock in other writings, most notably in his 2003 ‘Afterword’ to *The Machiavellian Moment*, reaffirmed his earlier point of 1975, that the *vita activa*, the classical republican life devoted to political action, was replaced over time by one focussed on ‘human behaviour’ or ‘the rise of the social’, following the title of the sixth chapter of Arendt’s *The Human Condition*.¹¹ Pocock is often held to have been a disciple of Arendt’s, who provided a historical background to her political philosophy. As Robertson and Mira Siegelberg argue, this is a mistake.¹² Pocock never asserted that the problems

of the present could be solved by the assertion of civic virtue. Pocock was not a republican and refused US citizenship, maintaining throughout his long life both his identity as a New Zealander and a British (subsequently New Zealand) passport.¹³ Although Arendt was sometimes critical of the United States, she was far more critical of Britain, and ultimately defended the United States as the only modern example of a free state that was also a superpower.¹⁴ Pocock, by contrast, was much more critical of the United States as a republic, and identified Britain's decline as a free state and empire as one of the great transformations of the twentieth century; a collapse whose implications were still being played out, he felt, in the early twenty-first century, with unforeseen consequences for all of the remaining free states and the future of liberty itself.

Pocock's professorial appointment when he moved to the United States was in political science and history. And with Melvin Richter (City University of New York) and others he founded the Conference for the Study of Political Thought (CSPT). It was at a CSPT gathering that Pocock came face to face with Arendt, who apparently reported that he was 'quite a good' historian.¹⁵ But he turned to her work because of the rapid whirl of composing the final chapters of *The Machiavellian Moment*, a volume which had originally been planned as a thirteen-chapter book, in part to antagonise Straussians.¹⁶ Something obscure had happened and continued to shape the politics of the United States. Pocock moved at high speed, at the end of *The Machiavellian Moment* from *homo mercator*, the object of criticism by *homo politicus*, to *homo creditor*, the figure equally 'discredited by his failure to meet the standards set by *homo politicus*.' The civic humanist critique of commerce was alive and well across the West. But what was distinctive about the United States remained at issue. Pocock concluded that somehow North America lacked a *homo faber* who would turn socialist or Marxist as readily as his European counterparts:

... even in America a liberal work ethic has historically suffered from the guilt imposed on it by its inability to define for itself a virtue that saves it from corruption; the descent from Daniel Boone to Willy Loman is seen as steady and uninterrupted. But one figure from the American gallery is missing, curiously enough, from the history even of the American work ethic: the *homo faber* of the European idealist and socialist traditions, who served to bridge the gap between the myths of the bourgeoisie and the proletariat.¹⁷

Like Hegel and Turner, however, Pocock then relied on the frontier as the explanation for the failure of the Left in the United States, while admitting that a full explanation was beyond him:

It is not yet as clear as it might be how the emergence of this figure [*homo faber*] is related to the European debate between virtue and commerce; but because industrial labour in America conquered a wilderness rather than transforming an ancient agrarian landscape, *homo faber* in this continent is seen as conquering space rather than transforming history, and the American work force has been even less willing than the European to see itself as a true proletariat. The ethos of socialism has consequently been an importation of transplanted intellectual... and has remained in many ways subject to the messianic populisms of the westward movement.¹⁸

Rather than making an Arendtian point about the decline of civic virtue and the need for its reassertion, Pocock was vague on what happened precisely to the classical republican or civic humanist tradition after the eighteenth century, in the United States or anywhere else. However, he continued to be obsessed by states and their frontiers, defined by land or sea, as the volumes attest.

This article attempts to show how Pocock addressed this particular theme in his self-reflective final writings and letters, published or written between 2014 and his death in 2023. Here he tackles the question of how *The Machiavellian Moment* ought to have ended, and offers an explanation of what actually happened to the commonwealth tradition. Here, commenting upon his work as a scholar, from his first book *The Ancient Constitution and the Feudal Law* to the sixth and last volume of his *Barbarism and Religion* series on Gibbon, *Barbarism: Triumph in the West* (2015), Pocock emphasised the relationship between his own work and those who have tackled what has been termed the jealousy of trade. By this, we mean the commitment of national governments to the pursuit of markets and the defeat of rivals economically, often by war or the exercise of brutal economic control over another polity. Jealousy of trade, as a historical force which had altered

world politics, was associated most especially with the scholarship of István Hont. However, Pocock came to the view that he had been engaging with this theme long before he came to know Hont, as Pocock explained in his academic reminiscences:

[The Abbé Raynal's *Histoire philosophique et politique du commerce et des établissements des européens dans les deux Indes*] ... presents the War of the American Revolution not only as a French revenge for the Seven Years War, but as the culmination of a period in European history in which British "jealousy of trade" has led to a universal monarchy of the seas which it is the object of French policy to overthrow. This — I have come increasingly to see since completing *B[arbarism and] R[eligion]* 4 and especially in the year in which I am now writing [2019] — can be valuably connected with a process in intellectual history developed by the heirs of István Hont, and especially by Michael Sonenscher and Richard Whatmore, under the names given by the latter, of 'After Enlightenment' or 'The End of Enlightenment' (the title of Whatmore's *Carlyle Lectures* of 2019). It is derived largely from Hont's *Jealousy of Trade* and his other surviving writings, but I can claim a place in its genesis for *The Machiavellian Moment*. In that work I traced how England and France, from the time of the wars of the 1690s, reconstituted themselves as what we term "military-fiscal states", whose capacity for continuous warfare rested on public credit and national debt. This had profound political and psychological consequences, widely feared as corruptive of society as hitherto and traditionally based, and as transforming the nature of human society and even personality. I now see these fears as continuous throughout the history of discourse in eighteenth-century England, where every successful war against France is followed by a revulsion against the regime which has made success possible, and particularly against the increase of national debt. While writing these memoirs, I have happened to re-read Macaulay's *History of England* — a history of the reign of William III — and I have been struck by his emphasis on the national debt then instituted as a source of wealth, power and stability. It was at the same time a source of disquiet and changes in the conduct of political power, which make themselves felt through the reign of George III.¹⁹

The full story of Pocock's ever-deepening fascination with the implications of the jealousy of trade will not be recounted here, as it would need to include all of the *Barbarism and Religion* volumes, which Pocock thought more important than his other work (regretting that these were largely neglected by fellow scholars).

II

Pocock asserted that a world in which giant monarchical empires aspired to establish a universal monarchy in the image of Rome was no longer, by the early eighteenth century, a monster to be feared. But it had been replaced by something very different, by the ambitions of states to control commerce, to interfere with the politics of their rivals, and, ideally, by exercising some influence on foreign economies, to secure and expand their own trade. New threats and risks emerged, especially as Britain and France, each seaborne empires, battled to be the dominant commercial power. One of the major consequences was the shattering of assumptions that trade would be a force for peace, which brought communities together by way of the politeness and toleration vital to the exchange of goods. Related hopes that because of a shared cosmopolitan cultures (*Sittlichkeit*), or a shared respect for laws derived from human nature, a peaceful world without states or borders might be established, became altogether utopian in such conditions:

There was a utopia in which commerce replaced war and empire; but its antithesis was an immediate reality. There was taking shape a counter-image which we still employ: that of a 'second Hundred Years War', in which Britain and France fought for supremacy — and, it was easy to add, a new form of universal monarchy — less in Europe than on the oceans of a global commerce, in a colonised North America and Caribbean and a partly subjugated India. The question was whether a global commerce rendered a military and naval struggle for empire necessary or not; and this is the reason why a key concept in the recent historiography of political thought has been that first coined by Hume: 'jealousy of trade.'²⁰

One of Pocock's major concerns as he got older was to engage with Hont on global commerce and its implications. This turn, an increasing fascination with the consequences of the jealousy of trade, altered Pocock's self-perception of what he was doing as a historian of the history of political thought and historiography.²¹ It also allowed him to explain what happened to the republican tradition at the end of the eighteenth century, while also offering a new explanation for some of the

differences between the European commercial states and the United States of America. He felt he could use Hont to explain the process, but all the while adding his own insights, not least on the collapse of enlightenment into fanaticism, and on the reasons why the rhythm remained different in North America and other empires established by settler colonies. Pocock also felt that Hont had missed the theological dimension of Hume's account of the rise and threat of public credit: there was a parallel with social movements that were unmoored from reality yet saw themselves as acting in accordance with the will of God. This reflected the respective focus of Hont upon Adam Smith and of Pocock upon Edmund Burke.²² Channeling Burke, Pocock understood the full implications of the ways jealousy of trade created extreme conditions in which republics might be established – in effect Machiavellian moments that arose out of economic injustice or perceived economic collapse – but which then turned fanatic as the new republican churches they created turned upon each other. These factors explained the period from the collapse of the monarchical constitution in France to the rise of Bonaparte. In addition, Pocock argued, similar trends were visible in today's populisms, as citizens suffering from the effects of the jealousy of trade turned afresh to the fantasy politics of revolutionary transformation or republican renewal.

When Pocock first became aware of Hont's work, in the late 1970s, he had become, with Quentin Skinner, one of the two leading historians of political thought in the English-speaking world and beyond. This reputation rested largely on two works, *The Machiavellian Moment* (1975) and *The Political Works of James Harrington* (1978).²³ The latter book is sometimes neglected, but in his recollections Pocock always emphasised that his edition of Harrington had taken him well over a decade to complete. He had started the project in New Zealand and continued working on it for eight years at Washington University in St Louis, Missouri, where he and his family moved in 1966.²⁴ As well as confirming Pocock's view of the significance of Harrington, the volume also exemplified one of the principal tasks of historians of political thought and historiography. Following Peter Laslett's editions of Filmer and of Locke, there was an expectation that editorial work of this sort would demonstrate the transformative effects of the contextualist method.²⁵ Both works, naturally, cemented Pocock's reputation as the pre-eminent contemporary scholar of the republican tradition, which in Pocock's story could be traced from Greece to Rome to the medieval Italian republics to early modern England and then to the new American republic.²⁶

According to the story Pocock presented in the 1970s, neo-Harringtonian republicans, sceptical of the selfishness and loss of identity that accompanied the pursuit of wealth and trade, had drawn upon the classical past to launch sustained critiques of commercial society. Whereas Harrington was the champion of the gentry, the neo-Harringtonians, as post-1688 defenders of a wise aristocracy, had merged a civic humanist language with that of the ancient constitution.²⁷ Pocock later made the point that John Adams was probably the only true neo-Harringtonian in America, at least among the major figures of the Founding generation. His 'Dissertation on the Canon and Feudal Law' of 1765 was, Pocock said 'the most misunderstood book since the Bible'.²⁸ Pocock felt *The Machiavellian Moment* needed to be added to this canon.

For commonwealthmen or civic humanists, especially those in North America, the hope was, Pocock held, that the evils of commerce might be mitigated by individual or familial land ownership, whereby a less dangerous and more stable form of agrarian-commercial society might be established. The realisation of such neo-Harringtonian and classical republican visions, which were rooted in land as the foundation of all virtue, relied, Pocock believed, upon a singular course of economic change. Such programmes could only become a practical possibility if the circumstances were right. In England the gentry had to rise. But in other parts of the world, and ultimately possibly even in Britain itself, the waging of war for the acquisition of land was a necessary part of the process.

In the Americas land could be made abundant for settlers through fighting native peoples, forcing their displacement by way of destroying the natural economies that sustained them. In Europe, by contrast, wild schemes of land redistribution depended on wiping out landed aristocracies via popular revolution as a means to implement agrarian laws. Civic humanism could lead politics

in a multitude of directions, with Neo-Harringtonianism being one of these directions, but the core elements were rejection of the pursuit of commerce for its own sake and the abandonment of state policies dedicated to the expansion of markets. Of course, the point needs to be made, of which Pocock was very much aware, that from the perspective of native peoples across the Americas and Oceania, the expropriation of their land was the very essence of the jealousy of trade in action, notwithstanding the ways in which immigrant settler communities described such processes of acquisition.²⁹ The republicanism of the Founding Fathers was a response to the jealousy of trade of the British, and they immediately pursued policies of this kind with regard to the native Americans.

But in their analyses of Europe, there was an explicit gulf between Hont and Pocock. Hont's emphasised the jealousy of trade as a force in world history, from the eighteenth century onwards, which profoundly shaped the domestic and international politics of every state. Hont was an unorthodox realist, convinced that restoring an eighteenth-century intellectual framework for understanding the present was vital if free states were to be maintained.³⁰ Pocock's story was one of lament for worlds turned upside down and then eaten up by commerce, and how an intellectual armoury had been forged against the jealousy of trade. Pocock tried to work out how their apparently separate perspectives – one emphasising the loss of autonomy accompanying the collapse of civic humanism, the other the effects of the jealousy of trade as fundamental reality – might be reconciled. The main argument here is that the consequences for Pocock's later work were profound, as he reached the conclusion that jealousy of trade both caused the French Revolution and unleashed forces that were the very essence of a nightmare for Commonwealthmen. As he put it in a letter of 2018 reflecting on what he had been doing, 'István is really the presence at our feast, isn't he?'³¹

III

Pocock had engaged with Hont's work from the late 1970s, when it was most concerned with the natural jurisprudential origins of political economy, especially in the period between Samuel Pufendorf and Adam Smith. Later Pocock lauded Hont, as well as Michael Sonenscher and other scholars associated with them, for having taken the history of political thought in directions which Pocock recalled he could hardly have imagined when *The Machiavellian Moment* appeared.³²

Early in their relationship, from the early 1980s, Pocock recognised that Hont's approach to the eighteenth century posed a challenge. At times he found it difficult to work out how to relate what Hont's arguments about commercial society with his own account of the ongoing history, especially in Britain and North America, of republican and neo-Harringtonian ideas. The latter, after all, affirmed a critique of commerce for fostering an individualism and selfishness that undermined the republican personality. Commercial society, in turn, critics had perceived as a realm of fantasy and madness, especially after the popping of John Law's Mississippi Bubble and the London South Sea stock collapse that followed. Circumstances where humans could not have confidence in anything around them, or trust anyone from beyond their immediate family, created a breeding ground for various social diseases. Civil violence, religious fanaticism and xenophobic or nationalist-inspired war were likely to follow. All three forces were manifest in eighteenth-century Britain, which many expected to decline as fast as the Dutch commercial society they were imitating.

Hont's response to Pocock's account of the civic humanist tradition was that it belonged to the past rather than the future. Machiavellian moments were no longer relevant to the world of reason-of-state, except in the all-too-rare circumstances of states which expropriated land from hunter-gatherers and presented themselves as classical republicans reborn. Hont never denied that Pocock's thought held good for the United States of America, whilst not himself interested in a place where such self-descriptions masked the brutal if haphazard exercise of commercial necessity, something that was clear from Jefferson's Louisiana purchase and the actions of the first governments of the polity towards native Americans.³³

The North American self-description of utopian farmers, popularised by Michel-Guillaume Saint-Jean de Crèvecoeur's *Letters from an American Farmer* from 1782, was a fantasy land characteristic of the cultures of the jealousy of trade, and the victims were the native peoples and non-Americans to the south and to the west. Those who saw themselves as republican farmers, latter-day reincarnations of Cincinnatus, who spoke of the public good and the maintenance, through virtuous citizenship, of republican values in the United States, were for Hont among the most deluded people upon the planet. He, after all, hailed from Budapest in Soviet Bloc Hungary, a crucial city in another republican empire, in which Communist rhetoric sounded very much like the civic pieties of certain Founding Fathers on land and virtue, but with different consequences for dissidents.

But Hont regarded the history of the United States in the eighteenth or nineteenth centuries as less influential than Europe, where the full effects of commercial modernity were playing out with profound implications – including potentially extinction or at least existence on the knife-edge of decline – for every single state or community. And Hont's rejection of Pocock's story, in the sense that he felt it had come to a terminal point or described a deluded reality, was evident in his choice of Pocock's term 'neo-Machiavellian political economy' to describe the political thought of England between 1688 and the Peace of Utrecht in 1713.³⁴

The implication of Hont's work was that what Pocock called the 'enlightened narrative' – histories that purported to explain the laws and policies underpinning the states of the Utrecht system – was naïve or utopian.³⁵ Neo-Machiavellians were already justifying the interference in neighbouring states or communities with a view to controlling their economies, as evinced above all by the English in Ireland. There were, therefore, species of Machiavellianism that had nothing to do with republics in crisis, that rather shaped the relations between states in conditions of commerce as reason-of-state. Neo-Machiavellian political economy was best described by Bernard Mandeville's *Fable of the Bees* in successive editions from 1705, or Montesquieu's Troglodytes in the *Lettres persanes* of 1721.³⁶ Republican hives that abandoned commerce were doomed to poverty and self-destruction. Trade generated self-interested solvents to the civic identities in which Pocock was interested. But it also challenged the very notion of an independent state equipped with strategies to maintain itself.³⁷

Hont contended that because Pocock in the decades before he embarked on *Barbarism and Religion* was less interested in French thought, he had missed the alternative agrarian, Catholic and 'republican' traditions that existed there, influentially espoused by François Fénelon or by the physiocrats. These visions of putting the good of all into practice, by radically rectifying the laws of land and civic identity, were very different from those of Pocock's American and English republicans and neo-Harringtonians. Hont made the provocative claim that Fénelon provided the intellectual basis for the anti-commercial extremism of Pol Pot's Cambodia in the 1970s.³⁸ An argument could be made, if one considers contemporary literature arguing that genocide was commonplace in the nineteenth-century United States, that the gulf between neo-Harringtonians and Fénelonians amounted to little more than window-dressing.³⁹ The question whether it is legitimate to make comparisons between the Khmer Rouge's massacres of between 1.5 and 3 million people and the Holocaust of European Jews or New World genocides is contested to the point of offensiveness.⁴⁰ But neither Hont nor Pocock thought in such terms, being concerned with the recovery of languages of politics through time and the range of political actions deemed justifiable within such languages, be they moderate or extreme, prudential or revolutionary. The fundamental point for Hont was that the grotesque extremisms of modernity could be traced back to eighteenth-century utopian schemes to defeat the jealousy of trade. Pocock came to realise that one of these modernities was the republican crisis of the Machiavellian moment.

Pocock ultimately accepted that the rise of the seaborne empires, and the world of debt and war which followed them, shattered the republican tradition and forced subsequent critics of commercial society to think differently. But there was one exception. Pocock compared war in Atlantic America, waged for sugar and for slaves, as one of reason-of-state funded by public credit. But he drew on the work of James Tully to argue that beyond the Alleghenies things were different

because agrarian settlements there were replacing hunter-gatherers, a process justified on Lockean grounds, but where the costs were not covered by states and where in consequence public debts were not being generated.⁴¹ Pocock always distinguished between empires of trade and empires of land, signalling the divergent strategies of economic control at one remove and direct colonial settlement. As the implications were different for the states involved in such activities, with no issue of public credit in one instance, the kinds of fanaticism that they fostered were also likely to be different.

IV

Pocock found Hont's conclusions both challenging and captivating. Around 1990 he seems to have accepted that his story was early modern while Hont's was modern.⁴² But by the time of Hont's work on Hume and national bankruptcy of 1994, a contribution to Pocock's festschrift edited by Skinner and Phillipson, he realised that Hont was moving far beyond Pocock's essays on Hume, including 'Hume and the American Revolution: the dying thoughts of a North Briton.'⁴³ Hont had by 1994 completed the series of essays that appeared in book form with a long introduction eleven years later as *Jealousy of Trade*. Pocock had long appreciated Hume's dystopian fear of the likely collapse of public confidence when property, rather than being tangible and real, was purely speculative and fictional.

For Hume the more a state borrowed from itself on the security of that economy, the nearer it came to dystopia: a condition in which the natural relations between proprietors in society would be replaced by those between manipulators of one another's confidence. The root cause of such a breakdown might be the jealousy of trade, that is the employment of war to increase commerce at the expense of one's competitors, and here Hume appeared to be arguing that competition for global commerce had created a new kind of empire. Hume died in 1776, appalled by the doubling of the British national debt to win the great war for empire that the Seven Year's War had become; he would have been further appalled, but not surprised, by its further increase during the War of American Independence that followed the earlier conflict. And the republicanism of the American Revolution was a response to the jealousy of trade policies of the British ministries seeking to repay debt after the Seven Years' War.

Hont was right. A new kind of politics had been established. And Pocock had an increasing sense that Hont's view of the eighteenth-century ultimately dovetailed with his own. Pocock was one of the readers for Harvard University Press of Hont's book in the early 2000s. He recommended that the collection of essays be published with a new introduction, leading to a fear, voiced by Phillipson among others, that calling for changes would lead the notoriously perfectionist Hont to rewrite and revise in perpetuity.⁴⁴

By this time Pocock's sense of working together with Hont on related subjects was strong. But there were significant differences. This is evident, for example, in their approach to the Anglican divine and political economist Josiah Tucker. Unlike Pocock, Hont came at Tucker via Hume and had no interest in Tucker's theological writings. Another division emerges when we consider Pocock's ongoing fascination with Edmund Burke. In consequence of his call for a 'new British history' from 1973, Pocock had been reflecting upon Franco Venturi's Trevelyan Lectures on utopia and reform in the enlightenment era, which he had heard in Cambridge in 1969.⁴⁵ The lectures and book that followed in 1970, formed a small but significant part of Venturi's *Settecento Riformatore* series.⁴⁶ Venturi had claimed that, compared to eighteenth-century Europe, in England 'the rhythm was different', in consequence of which the idea of an English Enlightenment made no sense. Pocock took the view that while English thought was indeed distinctive, there were shared cross-Channel languages which encompassed the same goals of enlightened peace and toleration. Hont consistently remained sceptical of this historiographical enterprise.

Pocock recognised that both Tucker and Burke were worried about the consequences of religious heterodoxy, which manifested itself in various languages of Dissent. The European philosophes

lauded by Venturi had themselves been influenced by earlier English deists. The anxiety of Tucker and of Burke was that such languages, when translated into politics, could readily descend into fanaticism, because behaviour was untethered from any limitations when it was seen to be in accordance with the will of God; worse still, any limits were irrelevant in worlds defined by the power of men to act as gods. Late eighteenth-century fanaticisms appeared to be replicating those which flourished on the extremes of the Protestant Reformation. Forms of practice termed ‘enthusiastic’ became commonplace ‘in which the human intellect worshipped itself as the only contact with reality, or the only reality there was’:

... the power-seeking *philosophes* of Europe had been derided more than they were feared by Tucker and feared more than they were derided by Burke. Both writers, however, saw them as products of English (and European) Dissent, who had secularized Protestant man’s loneliness before God into a caricature of man preceding society and history and seeking a mastery over both. Tucker saw Americans as archaic, slave-holders who did not understand man’s place in the progress of commercial society; Burke saw French revolutionaries as anti-Christ, liberated by the victory of the “monied interest” to repudiate that history and claim a revolutionary dominion over it. In my essay [of 1985] I was attempting to bring “clergy and commerce” together in an “Enlightenment” “conservative” in the sense that it took place within rather than against the progress of society; but this history must be made “English” in order to show in what sense it might be called “Enlightened.”⁴⁷

Pocock became convinced that both Tucker and Burke had defended an enlightenment which they had witnessed playing out in their own lifetimes. Europe’s religious wars had ceased because of the rise of states capable of tamping down domestic turbulence while at the same time subsisting in a balance of power sustained by commercial interconnectedness. An enlightenment of relative toleration was fostered in order to prevent theological disputation descending into violence. But Pocock had a historian’s insight that a period of peace was also the time to be wary of descent into war. The point of *The Machiavellian Moment* was to show that republics could never expect to be stable, would at some point die, and that the process would occur through various necessary crises of the republic. Hont shared this attitude to the past, holding that rich states were at their most vulnerable to decline at the peak of their commercial prominence, and the inevitable fall through competition with poorer countries, even if delayed, would eventually come. Republican existence paralleled that of commercial society in being forever on the cusp of collapse. Such experiences, Pocock felt, were currently being played out in the United States.

Pocock was positioning himself as a historian of the crisis of belief and its consequences. But the broader conclusion he reached was that the Utrecht system of states, the foundation of the international peace that Gibbon and Burke looked back upon, had failed. This enlightenment, which emerged in Britain after the defeat of Louis XIV had ended his aspirations to universal monarchy, rested on the employment of a standing army funded by public credit. Once again, the seeds of disaster had been sown in the course of victory. The jealousy of trade subverted the peace achieved at Utrecht, with societies where financial interests displaced those of trade and paved the way for war. Jealousy of trade played a major role in curtailing enlightenment, while also contributing to the republicanisms, sometimes fanatic, that would follow towards the end of the century.

The effects of the jealousy of trade became one of the central themes of Pocock’s series on *Barbarism and Religion*. In volume 4, *Barbarians, Savages and Empires* (2005), Pocock recounted Raynal’s diagnosis of the ills of the present in his best-selling *Histoire des Deux Indes* (1770–1780), holding that the British were seeking a universal monarchy of the seas and had provoked the French to take up arms against them.⁴⁸ Raynal and Diderot, who wrote some of the most incendiary parts of the work, wondered if the French foreign minister Vergennes had created in the United States of America a pacific Greek league of states or an empire-seeking modern equivalent of the Roman republic. Pocock was depicting a world driven by the jealousy of trade. Like Hont he charted the consequences of selfishness, the collapse of communities and states, and the possibilities for international peace in such adverse circumstances. But Pocock’s history was grander in scope, a story of Eurasia and the Americas, and encompassing too the theological consequences of the jealousy of

trade, which he held to be as significant as its economic results. As such, the jealousy of trade influenced Pocock's view of Enlightenment and enlightenments, but it also had consequences, he felt, for modern times; something which worried him at the end of his life.

V

Pocock thought that he had been describing the effects of the jealousy of trade as early as his essay on Burke's analysis of the French Revolution.⁴⁹ Burke's diagnosis traced the effects of speculative debt upon French society. He argued that France in the 1780s, desperately needing to find revenues because of the costs of defeating the British in America, faced a discontented 'monied interest' at the same time as conspiracy theories about the court and the debt were becoming ubiquitous, evinced by contemporary obsessions with the Illuminati. Property, according to Burke (following Harrington among others), served to anchor the mind in the real world. But as property became speculative and imaginary so did society. The fantastic republicanisms of the early French Revolution were related to the speculative manias that characterised the markets of the 1780s. As the landed classes lost their grip on public opinion politics became prone to fantasy and fanaticism in 'the revolt of intellect against property.'

This was the reason why Burke refused to countenance the abolition of primogeniture, against the arguments of his friend Adam Smith; who for Burke had inadvertently created a political landscape where – on the back of a reduction of the power of the landed interest and the authority of real property – radical republican experiments became possible. Burke won out in the 1790s, without being aware of his victory, because he died early in 1797, at a point when French republican armies remained dominant across the continent. But Pocock considered today's societies to be experiencing Burke's vision afresh. Populist movements across the globe Pocock traced to a credit economy which was successfully depriving the political community of meaning. When writing an essay for a symposium on the 40th anniversary of *The Machiavellian Moment*, Pocock was coming to the conclusion that prophetic status ought to be granted to David Hume's 1752 dictum that either the nation will destroy public credit or public credit will destroy the nation.⁵⁰ The United States, as the focal point of the credit economy, was both the driver of economic and political processes being followed across the West, and the source of a global culture turning increasingly hegemonic; all of which called to mind the factors which had given rise to the fanatic republican cultures of the past. Pocock was pessimistic about the European Union and the capacity of states to act as political entities in present times.⁵¹

As he aged Pocock became ever more certain that the practice of history was in decline. One of the signs, which concerned him personally, was the neglect of the volumes he wrote on Gibbon, which received fewer and less regular reviews with the publication of each volume. To the end of his life, he sought out scholars who would engage with all six volumes together and recognised that a project had been completed. Pocock appreciated that being in his nineties, many readers would presume he was already dead, and were likely to treat him as a fossil from a previous age, as such necessarily less relevant to the concerns of the present. But Pocock continued to read the historical writing of his contemporaries, including articles published in journals, and to write history. His final article appeared in 2019, a critique of 'global history' which asserted 'the unglobality of contexts'.

Pocock was never a Jeremiah, being all too aware of the inability of historical jeremiads to assess their own times with any accuracy. Nor was he concerned at the fact of change, accepting that he was, as he put it, the last of the generation of Renaissance humanists, and therefore likely to have a sense of not fitting in with subsequent generations who were differently educated.⁵² But he still felt that History as a discipline was in trouble. His worry about so-called global history in particular was its lack of attention to the historical languages – diverse, contradictory and flowing in different directions – that formed the context which might explain what historical actors, their collaborators and their critics saw themselves to have been doing, and what from an informed historical vantage

point they actually had been doing. This was lost in a form of scholarship that denied ‘the existence in history of any language-worlds persisting over time’ and which focussed ‘exclusively on speech acts which pass from one world to another – as if there could be a bridge without two ends to it.’ The result, Pocock said, was

a history in which there are networks but no communities and the historian becomes the ideologue of social media. It’s going to be hard work getting rid of this – in the past, I mean; in the present, it may be beyond saving.⁵³

The reason for Pocock’s concern was linked to jealousy of trade and its consequences. Jealousy of trade led to the establishment of commercial empires that justified their own actions by warping the past through the promotion of Whig histories. He had felt the full force of such history writing in challenging the dominant American historiographies of liberty in *The Machiavellian Moment*, without realising what the consequences would be.⁵⁴ It was therefore to be expected that after the fall of the Soviet Union and widespread assertions of an ‘End of History’ identical with the unipolar dominance of the United States as it stood in the 1990s, that Whig histories would proliferate praising this particular commercial empire. The danger was that such histories turned hegemonic, with dominant narratives emphasising the progress of human rights, of science or knowledge or any aspect of the present in contrast to a supposedly inferior past. All of this challenged the cultural diversity of historical writing; moreover, because for Pocock diversity and liberty went hand in hand, it also threatened the survival of free states.

The second reason for Pocock’s pessimism about History was connected to the way commerce operated in societies marked by financial systems partly geared to the provision of public credit. When the major commercial states sought to draw on capital globally, one consequence was a change of self-perception. The national or the specific tended to be replaced by the general and the cosmopolitan. Adapting Hont and following the latter’s view of radical Fénelonianism turned republican and tyrannical, Pocock argued that more substantive relationships based on land or other forms of real wealth could be expected to evaporate, and that personalities would rest on nothing more substantial than an assertion that they existed. Personalities could be expected to conform to waves of ideology, reality reduced to a product of the mind and the imagination.

It was Burke’s French Revolution all over again. The world was characterised by deadly economic movements derived from the jealousy of trade. One consequence was the unleashing of ideologies likely to support the building of empires, just as Burke had felt that the unmooring of property from reality had led directly to the imperialism of the First French Republic, all in the name of the cosmopolitan good of humanity:

... the transformation of property into credit, which permits the mind to break free from all property’s disciplines (Burke, who sees this happening with the Bavarian Illuminati and the Revolutionary confiscation of the goods of the French Church). You thus get a republic more expansive than the Roman, because there are literally no restraints it recognises (is it with us still?).⁵⁵

Burke’s cynical view of the French Revolution in action was that once the bonds of church, monarchy and aristocracy had been severed, other forces were required to generate social cohesion. The love of liberty was too contested to unite republicans for sustained periods of time. Nationalism filled the gap. Pocock’s worry in the present was that similar processes were underway: traditional social relationships were severed by economic forces; the humanist culture of the written word was being replaced by new and less context-bound forms of media, and ideologies self-presenting as global and cosmopolitan proved insufficient to bring actual people together beyond cyberspace. Pocock was sure he understood the movements abroad in modern politics, especially in the United States, just as he was certain that they presaged political turmoil. As Pocock put it in his *Reminiscences*, Burke had at the end of the eighteenth century described ‘a theory of totalizing revolution founded on the possible effects of the public credit whose advent I had studied in TMM.’ History was now repeating itself because:

... at the end of the 20th century with its genocides, gulags and great cultural revolutions, we were faced with phenomena not unlike those Burke had foretold, with his “mind of desperate men”, and we might compare our explanations of them with those he had offered of the phenomena he had detected. The move towards the globalisation of national economies was – I now write thirty-plus years after VCH [Virtue, Commerce and History] – to form part of the picture that has emerged.⁵⁶

Notes

1. Pocock, ‘Academic Reminiscences, written informally and by episodes’, unpublished manuscript, transcribed by Anna May Katz, volume 1. Copies of the manuscript are held at John Hopkins and at St Andrews.
2. Pocock, *The Ancient Constitution and the Feudal Law. A Study of English Historical Thought in the Seventeenth Century* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1957); second edition, *A Reissue with a Retrospect* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987), 322; ‘Machiavelli, Harrington and English Political Ideologies in the Eighteenth Century’, *The William and Mary Quarterly* 22, no. 4 (1965): 549–83; *The Machiavellian Moment. Florentine Political Thought and the Atlantic Republican Tradition* (Princeton NJ: Princeton University Press, 1975).
3. Colin Kidd, ‘Feudal Law: A Partially Neglected Theme in Post-medieval Political Thought?’, *History of European Ideas*; Eric Nelson, “‘Barons’s Wars under Other Names’: Feudalism, Royalism and the American Founding’, *History of European Ideas* 42 (2016): 198–214; Pocock, *The Ancient Constitution and the Feudal Law. A Reissue with a Retrospect*, 28, 321–323; *Barbarism and Religion Volume II: Narratives of Civil Government* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 112; *Volume VI Barbarism: Triumph in the West* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015), 464.
4. Pocock, *The Machiavellian Moment*, 548–549.
5. Pocock, *The Machiavellian Moment*, 548–549, citing Harold T. Parker, *The Cult of Antiquity and the French Revolutionaries* (1937), George A. Kelly, *Idealism, Politics and History: Sources of Hegelian Thought* (1969) and Crane Brinton, *English Political Thought in the Nineteenth Century* (1962).
6. Isaac Nakhimovsky in his recent *The Holy Alliance. Liberalism and the Politics of Federation* (Princeton NJ: Princeton University Press, 2024) has pointed out that the comparable empire for early nineteenth-century observers to the United States, because of the opportunities for expansion, was of course Russia.
7. Frederick Jackson Turner, *The Frontier in American History* (New York: Henry Holt and Co., 1920).
8. Pocock, *The Machiavellian Moment*, 549.
9. Pocock, *The Machiavellian Moment*, 549–550, note 82, citing William H. Goetzmann, ed., *The American Hegelians* (1973).
10. Pocock’s *The Machiavellian Moment*, 550, cited Arendt’s *The Human Condition* (1958), and an article by Peter Fuss, ‘Hannah Arendt’s Conception of Political Community’, *Idealistic Studies* 3, no. 3 (1973): 252–265. See John Robertson, ‘John Pocock’s Histories of Historiography’, *History of European Ideas*.
11. Pocock, *The Machiavellian Moment*, ‘Afterword’, 573.
12. Mira L. Siegelberg, ‘Things Fall Apart: J.G.A. Pocock, Hannah Arendt, and the Politics of Time’, *Modern Intellectual History* 10 (2013), 109–34.
13. New Zealand passports were no longer labelled with the phrase ‘British passport’ beginning in 1964 and stopped listing national status as ‘British subject and New Zealand citizen’ in 1974.
14. Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (New York: Harcourt, Brace and Co., 1951). See further Seyla Benhabib, *The Reluctant Modernism of Hannah Arendt* (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications, 1996); Richard H. King, *Arendt and America* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2015); Kei Hiruta, ‘An ‘Anti-utopian Age?: Isaiah Berlin’s England, Hannah Arendt’s America, and Utopian Thinking in Dark Times’, *Journal of Political Ideologies* 22, no. 1 (2016): 12–29.
15. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume I:
Other master spirits visited us, and I recall coming face to face, but no more, with Hannah Arendt. Some -- that is to say, Harvey Mansfield -- have described me as her disciple, but it is only one chapter of her work I have made central to mine, and I was told that she said I was quite a good historian, but she did not know why I wanted to be a theorist. I have spent much of my life trying to explain why.
16. Whatmore, introduction to the Princeton Classics edition of *The Machiavellian Moment* (Princeton NJ: Princeton University Press, 2016).
17. Pocock, *The Machiavellian Moment*, 550.
18. Pocock, *The Machiavellian Moment*, 550–551.
19. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume VI, entry for 11/28/19.
20. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume II.

21. From the first, as Caroline Robbins noted in her review of *The Ancient Constitution and the Feudal Law*, Pocock's self-presented identity was of a 'a student of the history of history': *The Pennsylvania Magazine of History and Biography* 82, no. 2 (1958): 223–25.
22. The best account of their differences, and of what they were doing as authors, remains Donald Winch, *Riches and Poverty. An Intellectual History of Political Economy in Britain, 1750–1834* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996).
23. J. G. A. Pocock, *The Political Works of James Harrington* (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 1977).
24. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume I, entry 'Washington University, St Louis, Missouri, 1966–74': 'We lived in University City, one of many corporations making up St Louis County, for eight years, during which I completed two major projects in research and writing: *The Machiavellian Moment* and *The Political Works of James Harrington*.'
25. Pocock, 'Present at the Creation: With Laslett to the Lost Worlds', *International Journal of Public Affairs* 2 (2006): 7–17; *Patriarcha and other Political Works of Sir Robert Filmer, edited from the original sources and with an introduction by Peter Laslett* (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1949).
26. Mauricio Suchowlansky and Kiran Banerjee, eds., 'The Machiavellian Moment Turns Forty: Rethinking J.G.A. Pocock's Intellectual Legacy', special issue of *History of European Ideas* 43, no. 2 (2017): 125–221.
27. Pocock, *The Machiavellian Moment*, 415–423, 458–459, 468–475, 546–547.
28. J.G.A. Pocock, 'The Book Most Misunderstood Since the Bible: John Adams and the Confusion about Aristocracy', in *Fra Toscana e Stati Uniti: il discorso politico nell'età della Costituzione Americana*, eds. Anna Maria Martellone and Elisabetta Vezzosi (Florence: Leo Olschki, 1989), 181–201.
29. Pocock contributed an essay 'Waitangi as mystery of state: consequences of the ascription of federative capacity to the Māori' to Duncan Iveson, Paul Patton and Will Sanders, eds, *Political Theory and the Rights of Indigenous Peoples* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), 25–35. He was especially influenced by James Tully's work, whose 'The struggles of indigenous peoples for and of freedom' appeared in the same volume. In *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume II, Pocock stated: 'James Tully's "Placing the Two Treatises" is one of two contributions to PDEMB [*Political Discourse in Early Modern Britain*, 1993 eds. Nicholas Philipson and Quentin Skinner] – the other is István Hont's – which seem to me, without being necessarily superior to their companions, to break new ground in ways vital to the changes research was beginning to undergo. Tully had already published *A Discourse on Property: John Locke and his Adversaries* (1980), *Meaning and Context: Quentin Skinner and his Critics* (1989), and *An Approach to Political Philosophy: John Locke in Contexts* (1993). In 1994 he delivered the John Robert Seeley lectures at Cambridge, and published them in 1995 as *Strange Multiplicity: Constitutionalism in an Age of Diversity*. Tully's work enabled me to link several projects in which I was already interested.' Pocock's assertion that Americans replaced hunter-gatherers past the Alleghenies has been widely refuted by recent scholarship. See for example Susan Sleeper Smith, *Indigenous Prosperity and American Conquest* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018) on the thriving agriculture of the Indian Ohio River Valley.
30. Lasse S. Andersen, 'Hont and Koselleck on the Crisis of Authority', *Journal of the Philosophy of History* 17, no. 3 (2023): 357–379.
31. Synne Myrebøe, 'A Letter from the Antipodean. J.G.A. Pocock's Account of His Biography from November 2018', *History of European Ideas*
32. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume II, 'Meanwhile, during those years, what I thought Burke was saying in 1790 came to be emphasized by Michael Sonenscher's *Before the Deluge* [2007], which presented France, in the years before the Revolution, as debating what form of regime could control the problem of national debt; and by the recent writings of Iain McDaniel and Anna Plassant, which ask whether economists saw the British regime, equally dependent on credit, as founded on a symbiosis of land and trade, supported by naval power, giving an anchorage in reality that would outlast Napoleonic adventurism. I admire this recent literature, not unrelated to the work of István Hont, but have not sought to engage in it.'
33. Gregory Ablavsky, *Federal Ground: Governing Property and Violence in the First U.S. Territories* (Oxford and New York: Oxford University Press, 2021).
34. Pocock's account of 'Neo-Machiavellian political economy' can be found in *The Machiavellian Moment* from 423–461. István Hont's essay, 'Free trade and the economic limits to national politics: Neo-Machiavellian political economy reconsidered' was published in John Dunn, ed., *The Economic Limits to Modern Politics* (Cambridge: Murphy Institute Studies in Political Economy, Cambridge University Press, 1990), 41–120. The essay was reprinted in *Jealousy of Trade. International Competition and the Nation State in Historical Perspective* (Cambridge, MA, and London, 2005), 185–266.
35. Pocock, *Barbarism and Religion Volume I. The Enlightenments of Edward Gibbon* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 132–133; *Barbarism and Religion Volume II: Narratives of Civil Government*, 304–305; *Barbarism and Religion Volume V: Religion: The First Triumph* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 386; *Barbarism and Religion Volume VI. Barbarism: Triumph in the West*, 1–9.

36. Alessandro S. Crisafulli, 'Montesquieu's Story of the Troglodytes: Its Background, Meaning, and Significance,' *PMLA* 58, no. 2 (1943): 372–92; Donald A. Desserud, 'Virtue, Commerce and Moderation in the Tale of the Troglodytes: Montesquieu's 'Persian Letters', *History of Political Thought* 12, no. 4 (1991): 605–26. Compare Hont, 'The Early Enlightenment Debate on Commerce and Luxury', in *The Cambridge History of Eighteenth Century Political Thought*, eds. M. Goldie and R. Wokler (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005), 405–407 and *Politics in Commercial Society. Jean-Jacques Rousseau and Adam Smith*, ed. Béla Kapossy and Michael Sonenscher (Cambridge MA: Harvard University Press, 2015), 44–45, 74.
37. Lasse S. Andersen and Richard Whatmore, 'Liberalism and Republicanism, or Wealth and Virtue Revisited', *Intellectual History Review* 33, no. 1 (2023): 131–160.
38. Hont, lecture at the University of Lausanne, 12 March 2012, 'Luxury and Revolution in Rousseau's Second Discourse', <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iOniStEYo2c&t=245s>.
39. Benjamin Madley, *An American Genocide: The United States and the California Indian Catastrophe, 1846–1873* (New Haven, CO: Yale University Press, 2016); Jeffrey Ostler, *Surviving Genocide: Native Nations and the United States from the American Revolution to Bleeding Kansas* (New Haven, CO: Yale University Press, 2019).
40. Patrick Raszelenberg, 'The Khmers Rouges and the Final Solution', *History and Memory* 11, no. 2 (1999): 62–93; Maureen S. Hiebert, 'Genocide, Revolution, and Starvation under the Khmer Rouge', *Genocide Studies International* 11, no. 1 (2017): 68–86; Jeff Fynn-Paul, 'The Myth of New World Genocide', *The Spectator*, 21 May 2023, <https://www.spectator.co.uk/article/the-myth-of-new-world-genocide/>.
41. As noted Pocock was profoundly influenced by James Tully's *Strange Multiplicity: Constitutionalism in an Age of Diversity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995) but he had been following Tully's work since *A Discourse on Property: John Locke and his Adversaries* (Cambridge, 1980) and *An Approach to Political Philosophy: Locke in Contexts* (Cambridge, 1993).
42. Pocock, 'The Political Limits to Pre-modern Economics', in *The Economic Limits to Modern Politics*, ed. John Dunn (Cambridge: Cambridge University, 1990), 121–141. 'The Economic Limits to Modern Politics', conference was organised by John Dunn at the Murphy Institute of Political Economy and Policy Analysis, Tulane University, New Orleans (13 March 1986). Hont contributed the (abbreviated) essay 'Free trade and the economic limits to national politics' to the published volume, but the paper he presented at the conference in 1986 was 'The Wealth of One Nation and the Dynamics of International Competition'. In the Hont archives at the University of St Andrews there is a longer version of the 'neo-Machiavellian political economy' paper (Universal Empire and Peace).
43. István Hont, 'The Rhapsody of Public Debt: David Hume and Voluntary State Bankruptcy', in *Political Discourse in Early Modern Britain*, eds. Nicholas Phillipson and Quentin Skinner (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press; 1993), 321–348.
44. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume IV: 'István had difficulty bringing together in a single monograph the papers designed to form *After Adam Smith* [Hont's earlier project] and it must have been about the time (1999–2003) of which I am now writing that I was asked by Harvard University Press to suggest ways in which they could be made publishable. In unity, I do not doubt, with others to whom the same enquiry was addressed, I proposed that a selection should be made and the author invited to write an introduction. I recall – as I hope I have not already recorded – Nick Phillipson saying "you've done it now; he'll try to rewrite the whole thing", but in the event the collection of essays published in 2005 as *Jealousy of Trade* has been the foundation of István's reputation.'
45. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume 2: 'In Cambridge in 1969, I had heard Venturi lecture on *Utopia and Reform in the Enlightenment*, in which he presented "Enlightenment" as entailing the presence of a group of philosophers offering a reform of society, and added that this was not to be found in 18th-century England, so that Gibbon, whom he termed "the English giant of the Enlightenment" had been an exile in his own country.' Pocock's 'British History: a plea for a new subject' originated as the first J.C. Beaglehole Memorial Lecture to the New Zealand Historical association, meeting at Christchurch, and published in *New Zealand Journal of History* 8 (1974): 3–21, reprinted in *Journal of Modern History* 48 (1975): 601–24 and republished with minor changes in *The Discovery of Islands*, 24–43.
46. Franco Venturi, *Utopia and Reform in the Enlightenment* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1970). See further John Robertson, 'Franco Venturi's Enlightenment', *Past & Present* no. 137 (1992): 183–206.
47. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume II.
48. Pocock, *Barbarism and Religion Volume IV: Barbarians, Savages and Empires* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005), 310–312.
49. J.G.A. Pocock, 'The Political Economy of Burke's Analysis of the French Revolution', *Historical Journal* 25, no. 2 (1982): 331–49.
50. Pocock, 'Afterword: *The Machiavellian Moment*: A Very Short Retrospect and Re-Introduction', *History of European Ideas* 43, no. 2 (2017): 215–221.
51. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume IV: 'Two and a half centuries after Hume, one and a half after Macaulay, it was possible – without rehearsing the history of the European states-system through the era

of German domination, or that of its world domination to the point where the second world war became an Asian conflict much as a European – to arrive at a point where industrial warfare seemed to have exhausted the state's capacity to conduct war and peace or even exercise domestic sovereignty, and the European states began entering into an association for which no strictly political term exists and they cede elements of their sovereignty to institutions designed for the management of an economy which largely manages itself. It is hoped to avoid the Humean situation in which nation and market are placed in opposition; but in the history of politics and the perception of politics, there have clearly arisen challenges to the notions of politics and history themselves, in which citizenship is thought of as participation in the decisions of a finite community capable of recognising and narrating its existence in time. The market does not seem to constitute such a community.'

52. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume 1: 'I was starting my education at the very last moment of the European Renaissance and the long history of the English alliance between the gentry and the clergy, which the founders of Canterbury had brought to New Zealand. Latin was the language of ancient Rome and the western Christian Church, and therefore the language of learning, or as it is now called education. I've worked all my life on the history of Western learning.' Pocock was a student at Medbury School, Christchurch, 1932–1937, Christ's College, Christchurch, 1938–1941 and Canterbury University College, 1942–1948.
53. John Pocock letter to Richard Whatmore and Brian Young, 5 September, 2019, papers of John Pocock, St Andrews.
54. J.G.A. Pocock, 'The Machiavellian Moment Revisited: A Study in History and Ideology', *The Journal of Modern History* 53, no. 1 (1981): 49–72; Pocock, 'Between Gog and Magog: The Republican Thesis and the Ideologia Americana', *Journal of the History of Ideas* 48, no. 2 (1987): 325–46.
55. Pocock to Whatmore, January 2020, Papers of John Pocock, St Andrews.
56. Pocock, *Academic Reminiscences*, Volume II.

Acknowledgements

Large thanks go to Colin Kidd and John Robertson for helpful comments on earlier drafts of this paper and to Colin Kidd for extensive editorial labours. We want to make special mention of Anna May Katz's outstanding scholarship. She meticulously transcribed John Pocock's 'Academic Reminiscences'; without her work this article could not have been written and we are enormously grateful to her. We would also like to thank Hugh Pocock and Stephen Pocock for permission to quote from the unpublished writings of their father John Pocock.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

ORCID

Richard Whatmore  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-1295-7558>

Lasse S. Andersen  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-3056-6668>

Bibliography

- Ablavsky, Gregory, *Federal ground: governing property and violence in the first U.S. territories* (Oxford and New York: Oxford University Press, 2021).
- Andersen, Lasse S. 'Hont and Koselleck on the Crisis of Authority', *Journal of the Philosophy of History*, 17, no. 3 (2023): 357–379.
- Arendt, Hannah, *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (New York: Harcourt, Brace and Co., 1951).
- Benhabib, Seyla, *The Reluctant Modernism of Hannah Arendt*. (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications, 1996).
- Crisafulli, Alessandro S. 'Montesquieu's Story of the Troglodytes: Its Background, Meaning, and Significance.' *PMLA* 58, no. 2 (1943): 372–92.
- Desserud, Donald A. 'Virtue, Commerce and Moderation in the Tale of the Troglodytes: Montesquieu's *Persian Letters*', *History of Political Thought* 12, no. 4 (1991): 605–26.
- Filmer, Robert, *Patriarcha and other Political Works of Sir Robert Filmer*, edited from the original sources and with an introduction by Peter Laslett (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1949).
- Fynn-Paul, Jeff, 'The myth of New World genocide', *The Spectator*, 21 May 2023: <https://www.spectator.co.uk/article/the-myth-of-new-world-genocide/>.
- Hiebert, Maureen S., 'Genocide, Revolution, and Starvation under the Khmer Rouge.' *Genocide Studies International* 11, no. 1 (2017): 68–86.

- Hiruta, Kei, 'An "anti-utopian age?": Isaiah Berlin's England, Hannah Arendt's America, and utopian thinking in dark times', *Journal of Political Ideologies*, 22, no. 1 (2016): 12–29.
- Hont, 'The Early Enlightenment Debate on Commerce and Luxury', in *The Cambridge History of Eighteenth Century Political Thought*, ed. M. Goldie and R. Wokler (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005): 377–418.
- Hont, István, *Jealousy of Trade – International Competition and the Nation-State in Historical Perspective* (Cambridge MA: Harvard University Press, 2005).
- Hont, István, 'Free Trade and the Economic Limits to National Politics: Neo-Machiavellian Political Economy reconsidered,' in John Dunn (ed.), *The Economic Limits to Modern Politics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990): 41–120.
- Hont, István, *Politics in Commercial Society. Jean-Jacques Rousseau and Adam Smith*, ed. Béla Kapossy and Michael Sonenscher (Cambridge MA: Harvard University Press, 2015).
- Kidd, Colin, 'Feudal Law: a partially neglected theme in post-medieval political thought?', *History of European Ideas*. King, Richard H., *Arendt and America* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2015).
- Madley, Benjamin, *An American Genocide: The United States and the California Indian Catastrophe, 1846–1873* (New Haven Conn., Yale University Press, 2016).
- Myreboe, Synne, 'A letter from the antipodean. J.G.A. Pocock's account of his biography from November 2018', *HEI*.
- Nakhimovsky, Isaac, *The Holy Alliance. Liberalism and the Politics of Federation* (Princeton NJ: Princeton University Press, 2024).
- Nelson, Eric, "'Barons's Wars under Other Names": Feudalism, Royalism and the American Founding', *History of European Ideas* 43, no. 2 (2017): 198–214.
- Ostler, Jeffrey, *Surviving Genocide: Native Nations and the United States from the American Revolution to Bleeding Kansas* (New Haven Conn., Yale University Press, 2019).
- Phillipson, Nicholas, and Quentin Skinner, eds., *Political Discourse in Early Modern Britain* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993).
- Pocock, J. G. A., 'Academic Reminiscences', unpublished manuscript, The Papers of J. G. A. Pocock.
- Pocock, J. G. A., 'Afterword: *The Machiavellian Moment*: A Very Short Retrospect and Re-Introduction', *History of European Ideas*, 43, no. 2 (2017): 215–221.
- Pocock, J. G. A., *Barbarism and Religion Volume I. The Enlightenments of Edward Gibbon* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999).
- Pocock, J.G.A., *Barbarism and Religion Volume II: Narratives of Civil Government* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999).
- Pocock, J.G.A., *Barbarism and Religion Volume IV: Barbarians, Savages and Empires* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005).
- Pocock, J. G. A., *Barbarism and Religion Volume V: Religion: The First Triumph* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010).
- Pocock, J.G.A., *Barbarism and Religion. Volume VI Barbarism: Triumph in the West* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015).
- Pocock, J.G.A., 'Between Gog and Magog: The Republican Thesis and the Ideologia Americana,' *Journal of the History of Ideas* 48, no. 2 (1987): 325–46.
- Pocock, J.G.A., 'British History: a plea for a new subject' originated as the first J.C. Beaglehole Memorial Lecture to the New Zealand Historical association, meeting at Christchurch, and published in *New Zealand Journal of History*, 8, no. 1 (1974): 3–21, reprinted in *Journal of Modern History*, 48 (1975): 601–24 and re-published with minor changes in *The Discovery of Islands*: 24–43.
- Pocock, J.G.A., 'Present at the Creation: With Laslett to the Lost Worlds,' *International Journal of Public Affairs*, 2 (2006): 7–17.
- Pocock, J.G.A., 'Machiavelli, Harrington and English Political Ideologies in the Eighteenth Century', *William and Mary Quarterly* 22, no. 4 (1965): 549–583. Republished in *Politics, Language and Time: Essays on Political Thought and History*. University of Chicago Press, 1989.
- Pocock, J.G.A., *The Ancient Constitution and the Feudal Law. A Study of English Historical Thought in the Seventeenth Century* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1957); second edition, *A Reissue with a Retrospect* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987).
- Pocock, J.G.A., 'The Book Most Misunderstood Since the Bible: John Adams and the Confusion about Aristocracy', in *Fra Toscana e Stati Uniti: il discorso politico nell'età della Costituzione Americana*, eds. Anna Maria Martellone and Elisabetta Vezzosi (Florence: Leo Olschki, 1989): 181–201.
- Pocock, J.G.A. *The Machiavellian Moment – Florentine Political Thought and the Atlantic Republican Tradition* (Princeton University Press, 1975).
- Pocock, J.G.A. 'The Machiavellian Moment Revisited: A Study in History and Ideology.' *Journal of Modern History* 53, no. 1 (1981): 49–72.
- Pocock, J. G. A., 'The Political Economy of Burke's Analysis of the French Revolution,' *Historical Journal* 25, no. 2 (1982): 331–49.

- Pocock, J. G. A., 'The Political Limits to Pre-modern Economics,' in *The Economic Limits to Modern Politics*, ed. John Dunn (Cambridge: Cambridge University, 1990): 121–41.
- Pocock, J. G. A., *The Political Works of James Harrington* (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 1977).
- Pocock, J. G. A., 'Waitangi as mystery of state: consequences of the ascription of federative capacity to the Māori' to Duncan Iveson, Paul Patton and Will Sanders, eds, *Political Theory and the Rights of Indigenous Peoples* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001): 25–35.
- Raszelenberg, Patrick, 'The Khmers Rouges and the Final Solution,' *History and Memory* 11, no. 2 (1999): 62–93.
- Robbins, Caroline, Review of *The Ancient Constitution and the Feudal Law*, *Pennsylvania Magazine of History and Biography* 82, no. 2 (1958): 223–25.
- Robertson, John, 'John Pocock's histories of historiography', *HEI*.
- Robertson, John, 'Franco Venturi's Enlightenment', *Past and Present*, 137 (1992): 183–206.
- Siegelberg, Mira L., 'Things fall apart: J.G.A. Pocock, Hannah Arendt, and the politics of time', *Modern Intellectual History*, 10 (2013): 109–34.
- Suchowlansky, Mauricio and Kiran Banerjee, eds., 'The Machiavellian Moment turns forty: rethinking J.G.A. Pocock's intellectual legacy', special issue of *History of European Ideas*, 43, no. 2 (2017): 125–221.
- Tully, James, *A Discourse on Property: John Locke and his Adversaries* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1980).
- Tully, James, *An approach to political philosophy: Locke in contexts* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993).
- Tully, James, *Strange multiplicity: constitutionalism in an age of diversity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995).
- Turner, Frederick Jackson, *The Frontier in American History* (New York: Henry Holt and Co., 1920).
- Venturi, Franco, *Utopia and Reform in the Enlightenment* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1970).
- Whatmore, Richard, 'Introduction' to the Princeton Classics edition of *The Machiavellian Moment* (Princeton NJ: Princeton University Press, 2016).
- Winch, Donald, *Riches and Poverty. An Intellectual History of Political Economy in Britain, 1750–1834* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996).